

ABID BHAT

BOILING WITH ANGER
Government job aspirants protesting in Srinagar

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official documents show, the JKSSB issued a corrigendum on September 14 after holding a pre-bid meeting with the prospective firms and amended the initial criteria, allowing companies that were previously blacklisted or barred to participate in the bidding process. Aptech Limited, a Mumbai-based firm, was awarded the contract in November, raising hackles—for it had come under the lens for examinations conducted in Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan and Assam.

In fact, the UP power corporation had blacklisted Aptech for three years—from May 2019 to May 2022—for allegedly facilitating cheating, which had led to the cancellation of the selection list of junior engineers in 2018. Then, in 2021, the Delhi High Court slapped a Rs 10 lakh penalty on it for "malpractice at an institutional level" after it filed a "misleading" self-declaration while bidding for a tender floated by the Centre's directorate general of training.

The firm's tainted past has forced many aspirants like Shahid Ahmad of Anantnag to travel miles to protest in Srinagar and demand the scrapping of its contract with the JKSSB. The 24-year-old graduate has applied for multiple government jobs since 2021, and claims he even cleared the police sub-inspector (SI) recruitment test last year, only to be handed the short end of the stick. In August, the administration scrapped the selection list of the SI and two other recruitment tests conducted by the Bengaluru-based MeritTrac and handed over the probe to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) after a government panel flagged possible "criminal conspiracy" among officials of the JKSSB, MeritTrac and a few beneficiary candidates. The CBI has so far booked about two dozen people besides filing a chargesheet, though further probe is underway to unearth the larger conspiracy and trace the crime proceeds.

"Such a horrible experience at the beginning of my career has shaken my confidence," says Ahmad. "First, it was MeritTrac, and now Aptech. We submitted a representation to the JKSSB against awarding the contract to Aptech, but in vain. It forced us to approach court. Now, we have come out on the roads."

In December 2022, a single-judge bench of the J&K High Court quashed the Aptech contract, finding the process to be "mala fide". It also directed the government to constitute a high-level committee headed by a retired high court judge to inquire into the conduct of JKSSB officials for their "brazen irregularities". But, on the selection board's plea, a division bench on March 10 set aside the judgment and remitted the case back to the single-judge bench to decide it afresh, and cleared the way for exams scheduled from March 16.

Amid the outrage to ban the firm, however, the board on March 14 deferred the test. Defending the move, Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha says the exams will be conducted once all doubts are dispelled. "Transparency is our top priority and there will be no compromise on merit," he adds.

But the chain of events has thrown into question the claims of transparency. Ridding J&K of corruption was among the main reasons cited by the BJP-led Centre for abrogating Article 370 of the Constitution, which provided special status to the erstwhile state. M.Y. Tarigami, a senior CPI(M) leader, says the administration needs to restore the confidence of people by engaging a credible institution or company for holding fresh recruitments. The anger, resentment and

GOVT JOB SEEKERS ARE UP IN ARMS OVER THE J&K SELECTION BOARD'S DEAL WITH A 'TAINTED' FIRM